

bad for your brain?

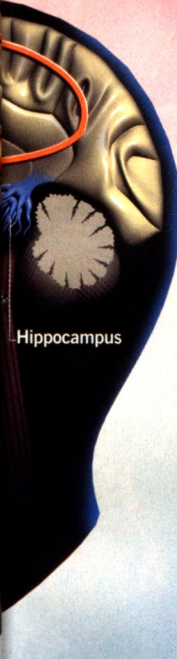
Scientists say it is ...

HIGH STRESS TAKES A TOLL ON THE BRAIN

- Over time, the area most affected by stress is the prefrontal cortex, the decision-making part of the brain. This can lead to impulsive, short-sighted, aggressive behaviour, as well as increased anxiety, depression, memory loss and other stress-related diseases.
- The body's natural feedback mechanisms break down. Even when you are not in a stressful situation, your body's activation remains permanently on and at a higher level. It can lead to high blood pressure, high anxiety, heart diseases, sleep disorders and more.

WHAT HAPPENS TO THE BODY UNDER STRESS?

- High levels of stress hormone (cortisol) short-circuit the hippocampus. Memories lose context and become fragmented.
- The heart beats faster, blood pressure shoots up, lungs hyperventilate, sweat glands get activated and skin tingles into action.
- Senses become hyperalert, on the lookout for further threat. Adrenaline shoots to the muscles, preparing the body to fight or flee.
- To ensure no energy is wasted, the body's defence mechanism shuts down the digestive process, leading to stomach upsets.



e-mail from the same colleague, he misreads its intent because his brain finds a negative match. Every negative match unleashes a reaction of roughly 1,400 biochemical changes (with cortisol, the stress hormone that is a major culprit in heart disease and diabetes, flooding the nervous system). His body has, over the years, adapted to living in perpetual state of negative, stressful matching, which keeps his blood pressure and cortisol levels constantly set at high. The moral of the story is, he suffers stress because of his inability to let go of recurrent stressful episodes.

It's 5.30 a.m. and the sky is clear after a night of incessant rains. But R. Chandrasekaran refuses to succumb to the temptation of sleep. He stayed up late over an overseas project, but he won't miss his routine for anything. He drives down to the Chennai beach for a quick jog. Half an hour later, soaked in sweat, he heads to the gym to tone up his muscles. As president and managing director of Cognizant, Chandrasekaran has enough and more on his professional platter. But the IT honcho recognises the pulls and pres-

sures of his job and the need to de-stress, "India's senior management may work hard. But they also work smart, balancing work and life." He is, perhaps, the best example. "Every summer, I take off with my family," says this travel buff who toured Cambodia recently and is busy penning his trip to Alaska. He is also a music aficionado and tries to stay in Chennai during the concert-filled month of December—the Margazhi season. "When I feel stressed, I unwind by listening to or composing music."

Is stress the main villain in a CEO's life? Not really. Increasingly, researchers are probing the upside of stress. "We may talk about cutting stress from our lives, but we need those precious, powerful hormones our bodies produce when we are about to be hit by a car or when confronted with an unexpected, needed-it-yesterday deadline at work," says Dr Ambrish Mithal, endocrinologist with Apollo Hospital, Delhi. "When the brain perceives physical or psychological stress, it starts pumping chemicals—cortisol, epinephrine (adrenaline) and non-epinephrine—into the body."

Instantly, the heart beats faster, blood pressure shoots up, senses sharpen, a rise in blood glucose invigorates us and we are ready to act—fight or flight. "Stress is a burst of energy," Mithal points out, "it's our body telling us what we need to do." Research shows that moderate amounts of stress can help people perform tasks more efficiently. Far from being something we need to eliminate from our lives, good stress stimulates us. "Think about your daily life—when do you get things done?" asks Mithal. "When you have a deadline. You want some stress to help you do your best."

Most successful CEOs seem to know this instinctively. "I believe in taking things in my stride," says Ashok Soota, 59, who clocks up 70 hours a week as the driving force behind the global IT and R&D services company, MindTree Consulting in Bangalore. He uses transit halts at international airports to take long walks. Mazumdar-Shaw prefers to reserve Sundays for herself ("to slow down my pace") and swims to de-stress. Khattar reads fiction and watches old Hindi movies to unwind. He also finds touring on work therapeutic. "It keeps me out of office and in touch with people." Godrej was into active sports—riding, sailing, windsurfing and squash—at one time. These days, water-skiing every Sunday with grandchildren is his preferred way. Paul enjoys speeding around in his sports car or cruising on his yacht. Chandrasekaran has a different take on stress. "It's a blessing," he says. "Opportunities are opening up all across the world. Working hard and smart is the road ahead."

If India is a roaring capitalist success story, CEOs have replaced the likes of philosophers and poets as national icons. But, beware, economic superstardom can come at a price. The moral of the story is: health and happiness are as important as the corporate bottom line. Those who don't shape up may just get shipped out to a hospital on a stretcher. Management gurus would, of course, smirk and say: "Yet another victim to the 'trap of overwhelming demands'."

with Nandini Vaish, Stephen David, Swagata Sen and Akhila Krishnamurthy